

CAVERNS MANUAL

In Caverns you play an alien adventurer lured into the legendary mines of Moria by tales of hidden treasure. Deep beneath the mountain lies a vast network of caverns filled with riches, danger and deadly surprises.

The mines are not deserted. Hostile dwarfs patrol the tunnels, spike-filled pits wait to trap careless explorers, and massive icicles fall without warning from the roof. Ancient lifts carry travellers through levels, moving bridges span dangerous gaps, and somewhere in the darkness lurks a scary Balrog.

Collect treasure, avoid hazards and survive the perils of the underground world as you venture ever deeper into the caverns.

Features

A completed version of a previously unfinished game concept on the ZX81:

- Designed for the 16K Sinclair ZX81
- Explore a sprawling underground labyrinth
- Collect mithril and jewels
- Avoid deadly spike pits and falling icicles
- Ride lifts and cross moving bridges
- Battle hostile dwarfs
- Encounter the mighty Balrog
- Classic monochrome ZX81 graphics
- Arcade-style action inspired by early home computer adventures

The Story

Rumours of vast riches have spread far beyond the mines of Moria.

Drawn by the promise of treasure, an alien adventurer descends into the depths in search of fortune. The journey will not be easy. Ancient hazards, hostile inhabitants and deadly creatures guard the way, and only the most determined explorers will reach the deepest caverns.

The greater the danger, the greater the reward.

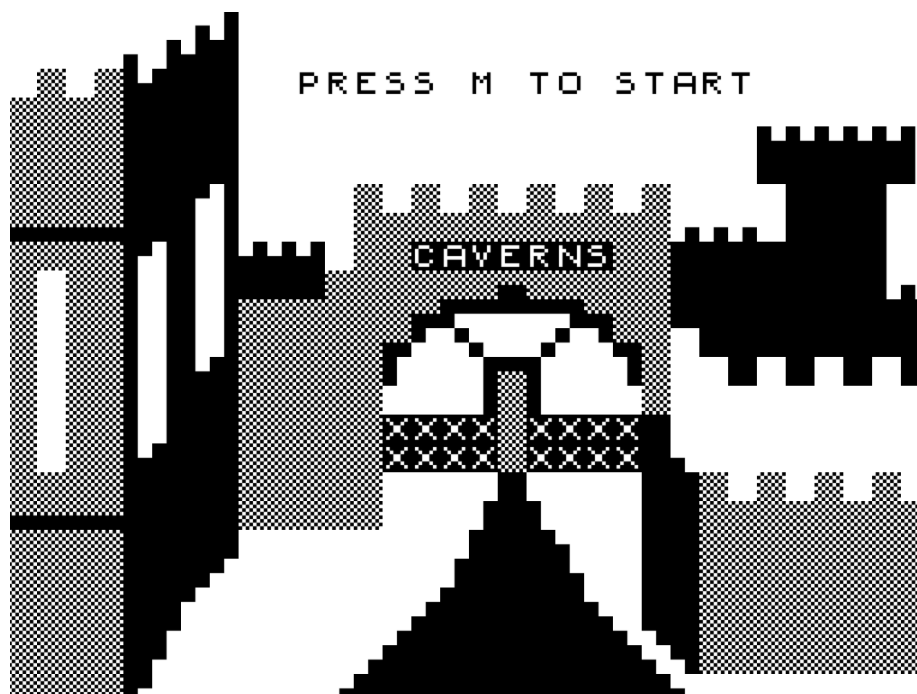
A Lost Game Completed

Originally conceived for the ZX81 during the early days of home computing, ZX Caverns remained unfinished on the ZX81 for decades. This release finally brings that project to life, allowing players to experience a game that might have appeared in the ZX81's day.

A lost ZX81 adventure, completed at last.

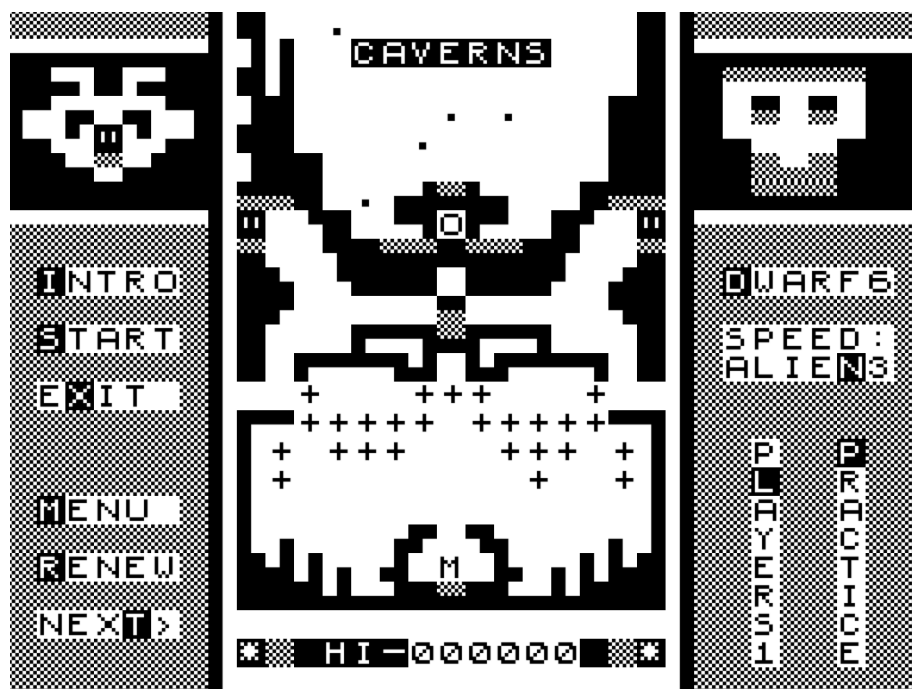
How to Play

Starting Caverns you are presented with the doorway to the Mines of Moria.



Press M to Enter.

You then enter the main menu:



The screen uses the ZX81 menu convention of highlighting the key to press in black.

So 'I' takes you into the Intro screen.

'S' starts the game.

'M' brings you back to the menu.

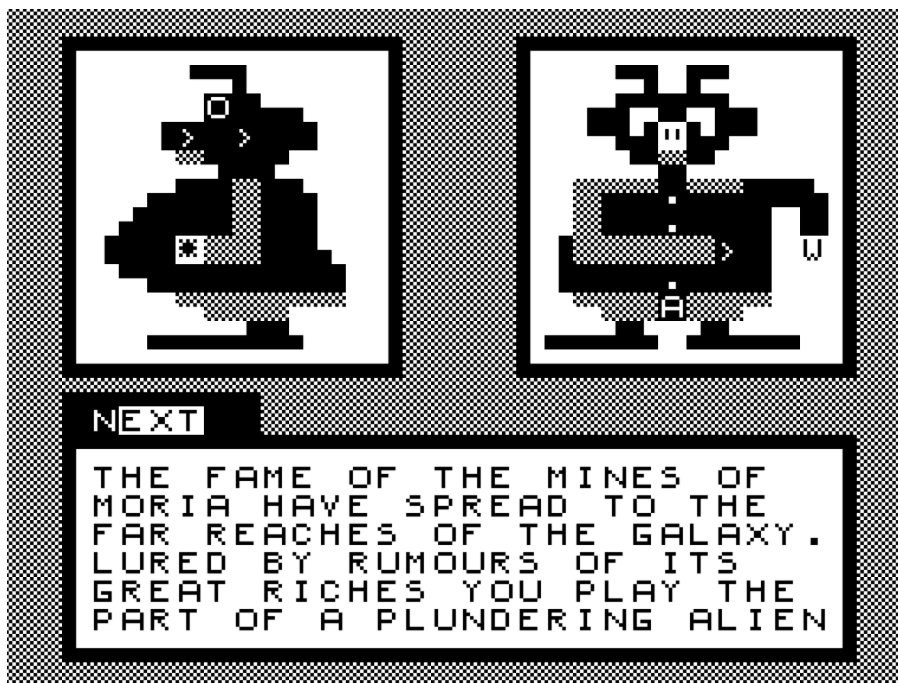
'D' changes the maximum number of dwarves onscreen from 1 to 6.

'N' changes the speed of the game from 1 to 5.

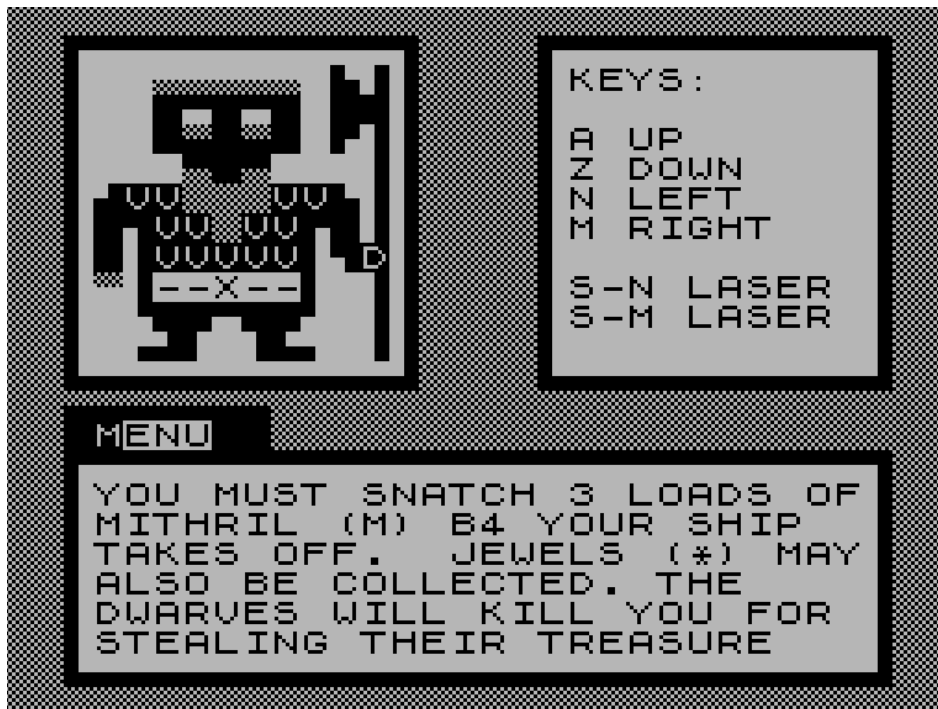
'L' changes from 1 player to 2 player

'P' takes you into the practice screen, where you go directly to one of the 6 screens to practice.

There are two intro screens.



The first intro screen explains the idea of the game. Press 'N' to go to the next screen.



The second gives more explanation – to complete a level you must get 3 loads of mithril 'M'.

(On one screen 2 loads are enough to leave the screen. I'll leave you to find out which.)

You can also score by picking up jewels '*'.

The keys to control your character are:

A for Up

Z for Down

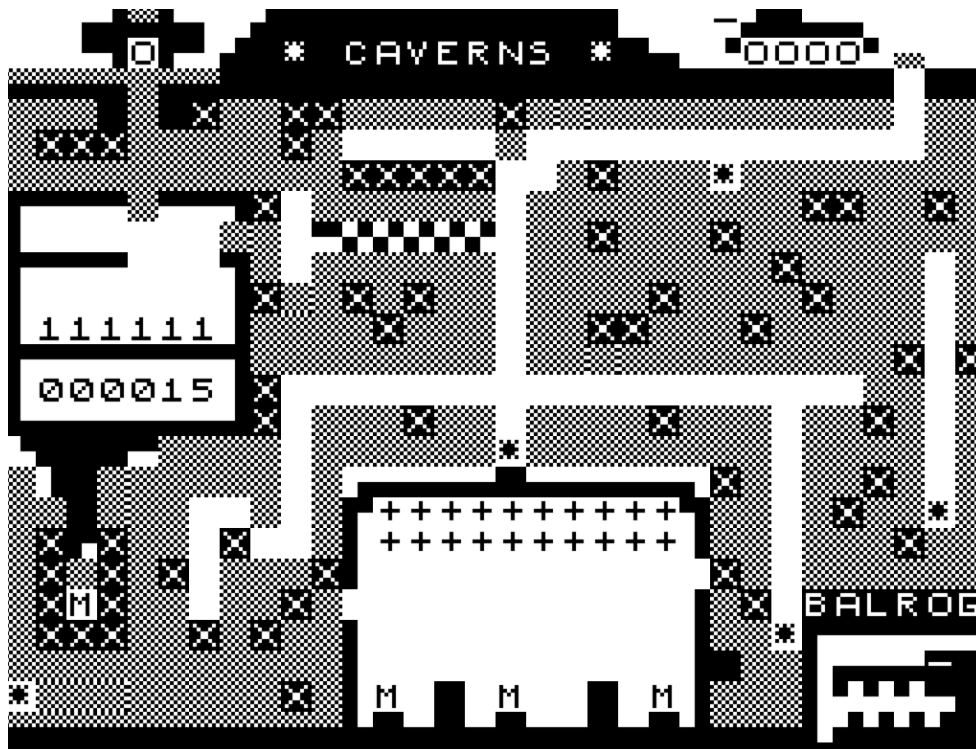
N for Left

M for Right

Shifting the N and M keys fires the laser left and right

The keys graphic might look slightly different on the ZX81 and Spectrum Next versions of the game as their keyboards are slightly different.

From the menu if you press 'S', this starts the game. You can play one or two player.



The first Cavern is the simplest. You must make a dash down to the central cavern and collect at least 3 mithril before leaving the screen.

Your spaceship lands at the top left and you control the 'O' character – the alien.

You can bore through the grey rock. Some of the rock is harder to bore than others. This uses a slightly different character.

The black X characters are blocks which fall, so you must keep moving if you are under one of them.

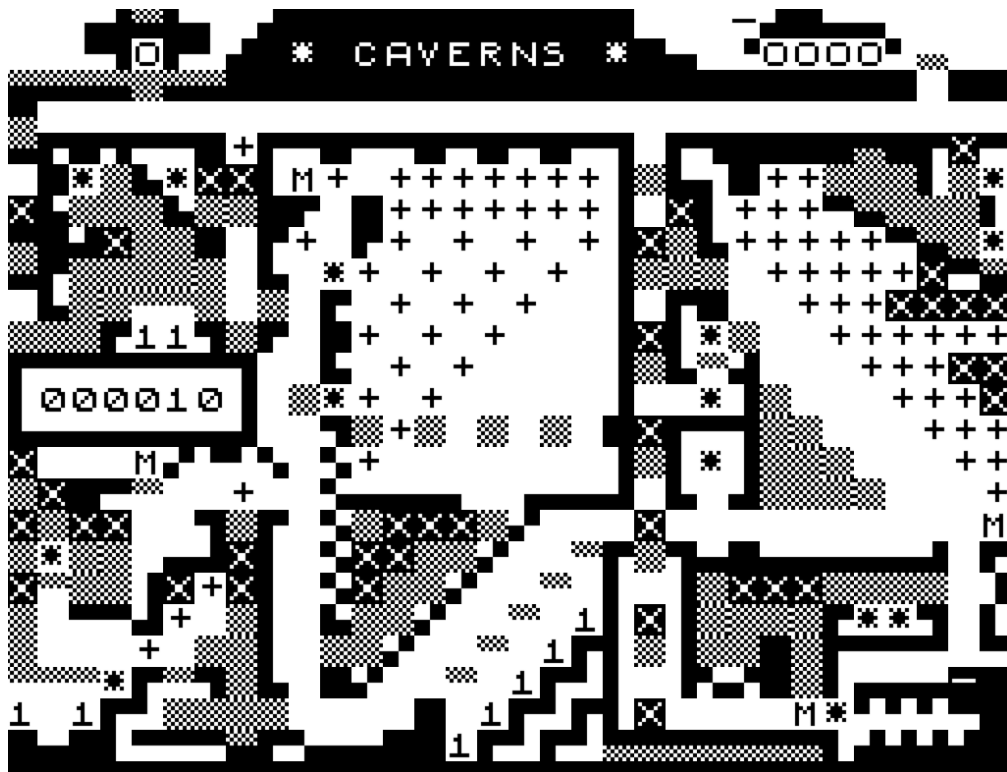
The '1' characters are spikes which you fall onto and die.

At the top right is a tank. This fires missiles at the rock between it and your spaceship. This acts as a timer. Once fired through your spaceship takes off whether you're in it or not and you will lose a life.

Dwarves enter the screen from the top right and patrol the caverns. Avoid them or shoot them with your laser as if they catch you – you die.

When you pick up 'M' mithril, the icicles '+' start falling. You must dodge these also.

Later screens have lifts and more bridges which you must ride. Timing is critical.



The puzzles get harder as you go further into the screens. There are 6 screens. This is screen 4.

If you get stuck 'T' takes you out of a screen.

There are trapdoors to navigate, and finally BEWARE of the Balrog.

Good luck